

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6
♥ K 9 2
♦ K J 3
♣ J 8 7 3 2

♠ Q 3
♥ A 8 6
♦ Q 7 5 2
♣ A K 9 4



♠ J 10 2
♥ Q J 10 3
♦ A 10 4
♣ 10 6 5

♠ K 9 8 7 5 4
♥ 7 5 4
♦ 9 8 6
♣ Q

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠		
All Pass			
2♠ by North			
7			

Surely this hand will play better in ♠s than in notrump. So you transfer with 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

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You pass. In the old days, before transfers, you would have bid 2♠ with this hand as a sign-off. The only difference is that now partner gets to play it.

The contract would be 2♠ played by South.

North plays 2♠. East leads the ♥Q and West plays the ♥9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total =

Suppose you win the ♥A, play over to the ♣Q, then try to get back to your hand with a trump to discard 2 losers on ♣ A K. If it worked that way it would be fine, but it is very likely that a defender would win their trump Ace, then take their 2 ♥s and 3 ♦s. You could be down one before you even got started.

A better approach is to trade one of your ♣ winners for a quick discard. Take the ♥A, then play ♣ A K, discarding a ♥ from dummy. That will eliminate one ♥ loser.

You probably cannot avoid your 3 ♦ losers, but you may be able to get out with losing a single trump. **IF** ♠s split 3-2, and **IF** you can win tricks with both the ♠K and ♠Q then you will make it. The only way it can happen is if West holds a doubleton ♠ A x. You must play the first ♠ from dummy, so ruff a ♣ to get there, then lead a small ♠, putting on your ♠Q when West follows low. This wins the trick, (hip-hip), so you now play your ♠3, ducking in dummy. When West has to take his ♠A, (hooray), you are home-free.

With West holding the ♠A, this Plan clearly works.

But, if you need West to hold the ♠ A x anyway, perhaps that first plan would have worked better. You know, take dummy's ♣Q, then play a low ♠ to get to your hand.

It depends on West. If he ducked the low ♠ then you could get **TWO** discards and make an overtrick.

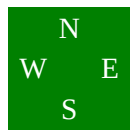
The method given here gives up the possibility of an overtrick for an improved chance of making the contract. You choose.

Board 3

South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8
♥ 7 5 2
♦ J 10 7 3
♣ K 9 8 5 2

♠ A 7 5 3
♥ K J 10 9 4
♦ Q 6 5
♣ 7



♠ K J 6 2
♥ 3
♦ 9 8 4 2
♣ Q 10 6 3

♠ Q 10 9 4
♥ A Q 8 6
♦ A K
♣ A J 4

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by South
or not to play the ♠A, that is the question.

Loser List: ♠ = 2? : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

At first thought it seems the ♠ lead has saved you a guess in the suit. By playing low in dummy you will force East to put on the King, (if he has it), winning the trick but leaving you with a pretty good position in ♠s.

That's why it's good to have second thoughts at the Bridge table. Think about the meaning of the ♠8 lead. If it is fourth down, then the Rule of 11 tells you that there will be 3 cards higher than the 8 spread among North, East, and South. **BUT YOU CAN SEE 4 HIGHER CARDS.** So your conclusion is that West has **NOT** made a fourth-down lead, but rather has led top-of-nothing, top-of-a-doubleton, or perhaps a singleton.

You don't know which of the above, but you do know that East holds both the ♠ K J. The danger is if the ♠8 is a singleton and you play low from dummy they could get a ♠ trick and a ♠ ruff. So don't play low from dummy. Win the ♠A at trick 1, pull trumps and then play ♠s from dummy toward your ♠ Q 10 9, giving East the ♠K but finessing him out of his known ♠J.

If East led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 2 then it wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If East led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 or ♠ 8 2 then it also wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If East led the singleton ♠8 then you had better play the ♠A or you will be down before you start.

It is unlikely that East would lead the ♠8 from any holding containing one or both of the honors.

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Feel free to use Blackwood. But if partner shows 3 Aces you only have enough points to bid 6, and if he shows 2 Aces you would still bid 6. So Blackwood will keep you out of slam if he has only 1 Ace. Or, you could just take a chance and bid 6♥.

The contract would be 6♥ played by North.

To rotate the hands and make South the declarer

South plays 6♥. West leads the ♠8. To play the ♠A